school where a number of children were killed, then this could be gleaned from the logs. And that, I'll maintain to the grave, is a crucial piece of information in the public interest.

Let me give you an example from Iraq. In November 2005 US Marines launched operation 'Steel Curtain' in and around the city of Husaybah, near the border with Syria. After seventeen days of fighting, the Pentagon put out a press release under the headline 'Operation Steel Curtain concludes along Iraq–Syria border'. Have a look, it's still there on their website. After a brief rundown of the objectives of the mission, the report stated 'officials reported that 10 marines were killed in fighting during Steel Curtain. A total of 139 terrorists were killed and 256 were processed for detention during the operation.' There was no mention of civilian casualties. That press release is dated 22 November 2005. Now how about this entry from the Iraq diaries we leaked, dated 11 November 2005: '[Patrol] in support of Steel Curtain reported finding civilian bodies buried in three (3) separate locations in Husaybah. At [first location] 3 females, 3 males and 1 child were recovered. At [second location] 7 females and 10 children were recovered. At [third location] 1 child was unable to be recovered . . . Neighbors positively identified all the remains and the father identified the remains of the child that was unable to be recovered. All casualties were recovered from areas attacked by coalition aircraft on 7th Nov 2005.'

You had to avoid bringing your own bias to the data and just let it speak to you. This was increasingly difficult for the journalists to do, and was one of the reasons that the issue of redactions became fraught. WikiLeaks, you must remember, was learning on the job, and I'm sure we improved, especially when it came to having a better focus on redactions. The data was giant and we might have failed to redact brilliantly at first, but the supposed concern of the United States government for a risk that remains merely hypothetical and unproven is a dishonest attempt to distract the public from the real truth about the Afghan war that the logs revealed.

Another erroneous report emerged at this time that had me saying we weren't responsible for the welfare of informants and that 'they deserved to die'. This is just nonsense: I said some people held that view, but that we would edit the documents to preserve their essential content and not throw harm in people's way if we could avoid it.

Throughout the logs' publication, I was aware that the redaction issue should not become an excuse for censorship. As we saw with Defense